

the senior management within IndiGo, we won't hesitate. We want to follow due process, but we will definitely take whatever action is required," Naidu said at an *Aaj Tak* event. IndiGo's Chief Operating Officer, Isidro Porqueras, appeared before the Parliamentary Standing Committee on Transport, Tourism and Culture on December 16 for questioning. The panel will seek accountability for the crisis. The Competition Commission of India (CCI) has also taken notice of the issue. "The commission has decided to proceed further in the matter in accordance with the provisions of the Competition Act, 2002," it said in a press statement.

Experts draw parallels to the 2022 Southwest Airlines scheduling crisis where US authorities imposed a \$140 million penalty, the highest ever on any airline. The incident, a result of outdated technology, inadequate staffing, and poor crisis management, led to widespread flight cancellations and delays during the peak festival season.

Will IndiGo meet a similar fate, or will it be let off with a rap on the wrist? And what can be the possible consequences? "Every year, there is a natural demand growth of 10%, but the capacity is not rising; in fact, it is declining. So, if you stop IndiGo (in terms of cutting its slots), you are stopping the growth of Indian aviation. That is because there is no strong alternative," says Gagan Dixit, Senior VP, (Oil, Gas, & Aviation), Elara Securities.

The fiasco is set to create a capacity gap that cannot be immediately filled by other domestic airlines as they face a shortage of aircraft. Air India CEO Campbell Wilson recently said that while the carrier will add 26 aircraft in 2026, any capacity increase is possible only in 2027. Akasa and SpiceJet are facing their own challenges.



PHOTO BY ARUN KUMAR THAKUR

THE NEW NORMS

- 1 PILOTS REQUIRED TO HAVE 48 CONSECUTIVE HOURS OF REST EACH WEEK, UP FROM THE PREVIOUS 36 HOURS.
- 2 THE DEFINITION OF NIGHT HAS BEEN EXTENDED TO 00:00-06:00, FROM 00:00-05:00.
- 3 ONLY TWO NIGHT LANDINGS PER WEEK, REDUCED FROM SIX.
- 4 PILOTS CANNOT HAVE MORE THAN TWO CONSECUTIVE NIGHT DUTIES.
- 5 AIRLINES MUST SUBMIT QUARTERLY REPORTS ON CREW FATIGUE AND ADJUST ROSTERS ACCORDINGLY.

Akasa is facing delivery delays and expansion challenges, while SpiceJet is facing financial losses and huge debt burden.

Ultimately, passengers are likely to be at the receiving end with capacity cuts on key sectors and higher fares due to the demand-supply gap. The government has capped fares for now, but Naidu recently said it is not possible to cap the fares for the entire year.

HOUSE ON FIRE

On-time performance, competitive fares, maximum crew and aircraft utilisation, lowest turnaround time (less than 30 minutes) and majority of aircraft on lease. These are the ingredients of IndiGo's secret sauce to keep operational costs low. It made over ₹7,000 crore profit in FY25 while other airlines bled. It reported a loss of ₹2,582 crore for the second